OSINT CASE STUDY

Yanbaru Shuzo Co., Ltd. (やんばる酒造株式会社)

Independent Verification of a Regional-to-National D2C Business Model

Takazato, Ogimi Village, Okinawa Prefecture, Japan

Subject	Yanbaru Shuzo Co., Ltd. (やんばる酒造株式会社)
Jurisdiction	Japan — Okinawa Prefecture
Case type	Business-model verification / D2C transition
Primary period	Historical record through 2026
Source basis	Japanese public sources outside the 2025 SME White Paper

RESEARCH QUESTION

Did Yanbaru Shuzo Co., Ltd. transition from a predominantly local awamori producer into a regional/nationwide direct-to-consumer (D2C) business, and can this transition be independently verified using Japanese sources outside the 2025 Small Business White Paper?

Prepared from public sources only. No private, paid or non-public data was used.

Research Question Did Yanbaru Shuzo Co., Ltd. transition from a predominantly local awamori producer into a regional/nationwide direct-to-consumer (D2C) business, and can this transition be independently verified using Japanese sources outside the 2025 Small Business White Paper? The research was designed to test the underlying claim rather than reproduce the government case study. The objective was to establish whether independent Japanese sources document: 1. the company's historical local orientation; 2. the emergence of a new customer acquisition and sales model; 3. the role of the Yanbaru Moai subscription/community initiative; 4. expansion of the customer base beyond Okinawa; 5. cooperation with local farmers and businesses; 6. the development of EC/direct-sales infrastructure; and 7. the extent to which the government's reported figures can be independently corroborated.

1. Company Profile

Yanbaru Shuzo Co., Ltd. (やんばる酒造株式会社) is an awamori distillery located in Takazato, Ogimi Village, Okinawa Prefecture , in the northern part of Okinawa Island known as Yanbaru. The company traces its origins to 1950 , when it was established as Takazato Shuzo. The company subsequently changed its name to Yanbaru Shuzo in 2017, reflecting a broader regional identity rather than an exclusive association with the Takazato settlement. Its principal products are traditional Okinawan awamori, including the Maruta (まるた) and Yanbaru Kuina (山原くいな) brands. Independent reporting by ITmedia describes the company as a very small distillery whose products historically functioned as local sake within Ogimi and neighboring Kunigami and Higashi villages. The same source describes the company's origins as closely connected to the local community: the distillery was established through local contributions and originally produced alcohol for local consumption and social interaction. This provides an important baseline for the investigation. The company did not begin as a national D2C brand. Its historical competitive position was based on:

- local production;
- regional identity;
- traditional awamori;
- community relationships; and
- consumption within northern Okinawa. The subsequent business-model change therefore needs to be understood as an extension of a local production model into new customer and distribution channels , rather than a complete replacement of the original business.

2. The Business-Model Change

2.1 Introduction of "Yanbaru Moai"

The most important identifiable turning point is the introduction of 「やんばるもあい」 (Yanbaru Moai) . The concept was publicly announced in late 2019, with the formal service scheduled to begin in January 2020. The initiative adapted the traditional Okinawan practice of moai (模合)

- a social and mutual-support arrangement in which members periodically contribute money and maintain an ongoing social relationship. Yanbaru Shuzo converted this cultural concept into a recurring customer relationship.

Instead of simply purchasing a bottle of awamori, customers became members of a recurring community. The original structure included:

- recurring payments;
- regular shipments of awamori;
- seasonal products from Yanbaru;
- information about the region;
- and periodic opportunities for members to meet in Yanbaru. The company's own announcement from November 2019 documents the structure in detail, including the delivery of awamori and seasonal regional products and the planned annual gathering of members. Importantly, this is not

merely a corporate description created years later. The initiative was publicly documented before the January 2020 launch .

2.2 Independent confirmation of the launch

The launch was independently reported by Ryukyu Shimpo , a major Okinawan newspaper. Its November 2019 report states that Yanbaru Shuzo planned to begin the subscription service in January 2020 and had already conducted a pilot event on October 28, 2019. Approximately 30 participants from inside and outside Okinawa attended the pilot event at the distillery. The project was also identified as part of the Okinawa Prefectural Government's 2019 Ryukyu Awamori Marketing Support Program , whose objective included expanding sales channels for awamori. This source independently establishes several important facts: 2019 - pilot event → external participants → subscription concept → regional products → government-supported market-expansion program → planned 2020 launch. This is significant because it demonstrates that the expansion strategy was not first documented by the 2025 Small Business White Paper. The underlying transformation was already publicly observable several years earlier.

3. From Product Sales to Customer

Community

The strategic significance of Yanbaru Moai lies in the fact that it changed the relationship between the producer and customer. A conventional awamori transaction is essentially: distillery → wholesaler/retailer → consumer The Yanbaru Moai model introduced a different structure: distillery → recurring customer relationship → regional products → community interaction → repeat purchase The customer was no longer simply purchasing alcohol. The company was effectively selling access to:

- Yanbaru products;
- the local production story;
- regional identity;
- recurring contact with the producer;
- and eventually physical access to the region itself. This distinction matters when evaluating the D2C claim. The evidence does not merely show that Yanbaru Shuzo created an online shop. It shows

the development of a direct customer relationship designed around recurring engagement .

4. Geographic Expansion of the

Customer Base

The strongest independent evidence for the transition beyond the local market comes from later reporting. In a September 2024 ITmedia Business article, Yanbaru Shuzo reported approximately 80 registered Yanbaru Moai members , with more than 90% residing outside Okinawa Prefecture . This is a critical data point because it directly addresses the geographic component of the research question. The customer base associated with the new model was no longer primarily local. Instead: ~80 members → >90% outside Okinawa → recurring relationship with a small Okinawan producer The same article describes customers travelling to the distillery after restrictions associated with the COVID-19 period eased, indicating that the subscription/community model also created physical connections between the company and customers outside Okinawa. This supports the interpretation that Yanbaru Moai functioned as more than an ordinary subscription service. It acted as a customer-acquisition and community-building mechanism for a geographically dispersed customer base .

5. EC and Direct Sales

The second major component of the business-model transition was the development of direct sales. ITmedia reports that Yanbaru Shuzo deliberately increased the proportion of sales conducted directly rather than through traditional wholesale channels. The company reportedly increased its direct-sales ratio while recovering from the COVID-era decline in revenue. The article states that annual revenue had fallen to approximately ¥60 million during the pandemic period , before recovering to approximately ¥80 million . The company attributed this recovery partly to its strategy of increasing direct sales and establishing a stronger relationship with customers. This provides independent evidence for an important part of the D2C hypothesis: The company was not simply acquiring customers outside Okinawa; it was simultaneously attempting to move more of the commercial relationship into direct channels. The company's current official website also demonstrates the continued existence of a direct online sales operation, offering awamori and other Yanbaru-related products through its own EC infrastructure.

6. Regional Network Rather Than

Alcohol-Only D2C

One of the most important findings is that the expansion of the sales channel was accompanied by an expansion of the product ecosystem . Yanbaru Shuzo did not restrict the new direct-sales model to its own awamori. The company increasingly incorporated products and capabilities from other businesses in Yanbaru. This is particularly visible in the development of:

「やんばるつながリキュール

スパイシーセッション」

The product was developed in 2022 as a collaboration involving multiple local actors. According to ITmedia:

- Yanbaru Shuzo supplied the awamori-based component;
- ginger was produced by a farmer in neighboring Kijoka;
- locally grown island chili was incorporated;
- a curry restaurant in Kunigami produced the special syrup;
- another local business handled the logo and label. The result was therefore not simply an awamori product manufactured entirely inside the distillery. It was a

multi-party regional product whose value chain incorporated several local businesses. This is a significant finding for the business-model analysis. The company was using its brand, distribution capabilities and customer relationships as a mechanism for connecting external consumers with a broader set of local producers.

7. Emergence of a Regional Marketplace

The evidence also indicates that Yanbaru Shuzo's EC strategy expanded beyond the sale of its own products. The company's online sales infrastructure includes products categorized asやんばるうまいもんand other regional goods in addition to its core awamori brands. This is consistent with the strategy described by ITmedia, which reports that the company's direct-sales facilities and online shop were used to sell products from Yanbaru in addition to the distillery's own products. This represents an important shift in business function. The EC channel can therefore be interpreted as: not only an online bottle shop, but also a regional distribution and customer-acquisition platform. The economic logic is straightforward: 1. Yanbaru Shuzo already possesses a recognizable regional brand. 2. It establishes direct relationships with customers outside Okinawa. 3. Those customers develop an interest in Yanbaru itself rather than only in awamori. 4. Other regional products can then be introduced to the same customer base. 5. Local producers gain access to consumers they would have difficulty reaching independently. The resulting model resembles a regional D2C ecosystem rather than a conventional single-product D2C operation.

8. Independent Source Chain

The central finding is strengthened by the chronological diversity of the sources. The transformation can be reconstructed without relying exclusively on the 2025 Small Business White Paper. 2019 - Launch phase Ryukyu Shimpo independently reports the October 2019 pilot event and planned January 2020 launch of Yanbaru Moai. Evidence:

- 30 participants;
- participants from inside and outside Okinawa;
- recurring purchase structure;
- awamori and regional products;
- prefectural marketing-support program. 2019 - Company's own primary documentation Yanbaru Shuzo's own announcement explains the intended structure of Yanbaru Moai:
- recurring contributions;
- seasonal shipments;
- regional products;
- community meetings;
- long-term relationship with customers interested in Yanbaru. This source is not independent , but it is valuable as primary evidence for what the company actually intended to build at the time. 2024 - Independent assessment of the mature model

ITmedia reports:

- approximately 80 Yanbaru Moai members;
- more than 90% from outside Okinawa;
- increased direct sales;
- revenue recovery from approximately ¥60 million to ¥80 million;
- collaboration with regional producers;
- direct sales of regional products;
- online sales infrastructure. This later source therefore provides independent evidence that the model described in 2019 did not remain merely an experimental marketing project.

9. What Can Be Independently Confirmed?

Claim Assessment Evidence Yanbaru Shuzo historically had a strong local/regional orientation Confirmed ITmedia; company history Yanbaru Moai was launched around 2019-2020 Confirmed Ryukyu Shimpo + company primary source The initiative targeted customers interested in Yanbaru beyond the immediate locality Confirmed Ryukyu Shimpo; later ITmedia The model used recurring/subscription-style payments Confirmed Ryukyu Shimpo; company Regional agricultural products were incorporated Confirmed Company; ITmedia Customer base expanded outside Okinawa Strongly confirmed ITmedia: >90% of ~80 members outside Okinawa Direct sales became strategically more important Confirmed ITmedia EC was used as a direct customer channel Confirmed Company website; ITmedia Other Yanbaru products were sold through the company's sales infrastructure Confirmed Company website; ITmedia Local producers collaborated in product development Confirmed ITmedia Yanbaru Shuzo became a nationwide mass-market alcohol retailer Not established Evidence does not support this stronger interpretation SNS alone drove nationwide expansion Insufficient independent evidence Government case provides stronger evidence than independent sources The specific 30% EC-sales figure is independently verified Not established Requires careful separation from other direct-sales metrics

10. Important Data Discrepancy

One of the most important OSINT findings is a discrepancy between different reported sales metrics. The 2025 Small Business White Paper presents an approximately 30% EC/direct-sales-related figure for the relevant case. However, the 2024 ITmedia article reports that the company's overall direct-sales share had increased to approximately 80% . These figures should not be treated as interchangeable. They may represent:

- different years;
- different sales channels;
- different definitions of "direct sales";
- or different denominators. The available evidence is insufficient to reconcile the two figures conclusively. Therefore, an accurate OSINT report should not state:

"EC sales reached 80%." That conclusion would exceed the evidence. The defensible formulation is: Independent reporting indicates that Yanbaru Shuzo substantially increased its overall direct-sales share, while the government case reports a separate EC-related ratio. The two figures should not be conflated without access to the underlying accounting definitions. This distinction is important because it demonstrates that the investigation is testing the source material rather than merely reproducing its claims.

11. Assessment of the D2C Transition

The available evidence supports a qualified confirmation of the central hypothesis. Yanbaru Shuzo did not abandon its local production model. Instead, the company appears to have constructed an additional commercial layer on top of it: Original model Local production ↓ Local/regional consumption ↓ Wholesale and traditional sales Emerging model Local production ↓ Regional supplier network ↓ Yanbaru brand / community ↓ Direct online and subscription channels ↓ Customers throughout Japan This distinction is fundamental. The company remains geographically and culturally rooted in Yanbaru. Its competitive differentiation continues to depend heavily on place, local products, traditional awamori and regional identity. What changed was the market-access architecture . The company increasingly gained the ability to communicate directly with consumers outside Okinawa, sell to them without relying exclusively on traditional intermediaries, and use the resulting customer relationship to distribute a broader range of Yanbaru products.

12. Final Assessment

Finding The claim that Yanbaru Shuzo evolved from a predominantly local producer toward a regional/nationwide D2C-oriented business model is substantially supported by independent Japanese sources. The strongest evidence is not the 2025 government case itself, but the chronological chain formed by earlier and later sources. The independent evidence demonstrates: 1. A documented 2019 transition point through the creation of Yanbaru Moai. 2. External customer acquisition beginning at the launch stage. 3. A recurring direct relationship rather than purely transactional product sales. 4. A geographically dispersed customer base , with more than 90% of approximately 80 Yanbaru Moai members reported outside Okinawa by 2024. 5. A strategic increase in direct sales. 6. Development of online/direct-sales infrastructure. 7. Integration of products from other local producers. 8. Collaborative manufacturing involving farmers, restaurants and other regional businesses. However, the evidence does not justify describing Yanbaru Shuzo as a conventional nationwide mass-market D2C company. A more precise characterization is: Yanbaru Shuzo is a locally rooted awamori producer that developed a nationwide customer-facing D2C layer and used that channel to build a broader regional commercial ecosystem. The transformation therefore concerns market access and customer relationships more than the geographic relocation of production . The company continues to manufacture a highly localized product in Yanbaru. What has expanded is the company's ability to connect that local production base with consumers and other businesses across Japan. From an OSINT perspective, this distinction is important: the available evidence supports a regional-to-national customer and distribution expansion , but not the stronger claim that the company fundamentally ceased to be a local producer.

Sources

1. Ryukyu Shimpo (琉球新報), 2019

- independent reporting on the launch of Yanbaru Moai, the pilot event, external participants and the Okinawa Prefectural marketing-support program. 2.

Yanbaru Shuzo - primary source, 2019

- original announcement explaining the structure and objectives of Yanbaru Moai. 3.

ITmedia Business Online, 2024

- independent reporting on Yanbaru Shuzo's direct-sales strategy, approximately 80 Yanbaru Moai members, >90% non-Okinawa membership, revenue recovery and regional product collaborations. 4.

Yanbaru Shuzo official website

- current evidence of direct online sales and continued sale of Yanbaru regional products alongside the company's awamori brands. 5.

Okinawa Awamori Association

- product and producer information for Yanbaru Shuzo and its awamori brands. Source Independence

For the purposes of this investigation, the evidence was separated into three categories:

- Primary/company evidence: useful for establishing what Yanbaru Shuzo itself announced or operated.
- Independent Japanese media: used to verify whether the company's claims correspond to externally reported events and outcomes.
- Government documentation: treated as a reference case rather than as sufficient independent verification. The central conclusion remains supported when the government White Paper is excluded

from the evidentiary chain.